Vetenskapsrådet

2026-05-29
2025-08215
Lindholm, Karl-Johan

Beredningsgruppens yttrande

Ansökans diarienummer	2025-08215
Nuvarande projektledare	Karl-Johan Lindholm
Beredningsgrupp	FI-RÅGA
Utlysning	Behovsinventering av forskningsinfrastruktur av nationellt intresse 2025 (Forskningsinfrastruktur)
Projekttitel (svenska)	Swedigarch. Nationell infrastruktur för digital arkeologi.
Bidragsform	Forskningsinfrastruktur
Sökt inriktning	Behovsinventering

Yttrande

Vetenskaplig relevans

Swedigarch stores and provides access to archaeological documentation, geographical information, scientific analyses, collections, and heritage archives by integrating data from actors within the Swedish field of archaeology and neighbouring disciplines.
Their work is fundamental to providing open access to diverse datasets, which, previously, were difficult to obtain and not possible to collate on a large scale. The work by Swedigarch has facilitated data comparability across actors, provided a standard for organising and integrating data, and demonstrated strong, generally well-argued scientific relevance, thereby enabling interdisciplinary research. The emphasis on cumulative knowledge building, reproducibility, and comparative analyses is a clear strength. The scientific relevance is also highlighted by ÄRK, although ÄRK-KKF does state that art research could have a more explicit and highlighted role. Given its stated interdisciplinarity, the proposal could benefit from more explicit examples of how Swedigarch-enabled research facilitates scientific results beyond archaeology.

Strategisk och nationell relevans

Swedigarch has both strategic and national relevance due to its vast amount of collated data. Its ambition to expand the datasets and add more resources is important. From a strategic and national perspective, Swedigarch is well aligned with Swedish priorities and demonstrates strong national anchoring. The broad user base, including authorities, museums, contract archaeology organisations, SME:s, and universities, is a notable asset.

Andra viktiga aspekter att ta hänsyn till

Although five different resources are currently operational, the diversity of the archaeological datasets is largely inaccessible, and work is still needed to collate and integrate different aspects of the record. Plans to include radiocarbon, dendrochronological, and aDNA data over the coming years are important and can provide insights into the interpretation of prehistoric cultures. The integration of other data types, e.g., osteological, protein and isotopic datasets, would also be important for future integration. If made accessible on a large scale and if related to the other planned datasets, it could facilitate a foundation for groundbreaking research. The increase to 25 FTEs is high, considering that the overall structure of Swedigarch is now in place, but could be used to diversify the datasets.
The relationship to adjacent infrastructures is generally well described, but slightly under-specified in operational terms. E.g. while Swedigarch does not duplicate ArchLab's laboratory services, the proposal could articulate binding coordination mechanisms to ensure efficient data flows, shared standards, and long-term coherence across the infrastructures, as is also noted by ÄRK-HS. It would be beneficial if Swedigarch could provide a clearer prioritisation, a more concrete articulation of the scientific impact, and a stronger operational coordination with adjacent infrastructures.
The proposal's emphasis on AI and large language models is forward-looking and potentially valuable but raises questions. While the ambition to make data machine-actionable is well motivated, it does not fully address the risks associated with over-promising technological impact, including maintenance costs, methodological robustness, and the availability of appropriate expertise. The assessment of socioeconomic and environmental impacts of AI components is mentioned but not sufficiently elaborated, leaving some uncertainty about how responsibly and sustainably it will be integrated.

Sammanfattande bedömning

Tom

0 - Otillräckligt värde

1 - X Need cannot be assessed due to incomplete information or unclear description

2 - C: Not relevant to be prioritised by VR, because need can be handled within existing national or international infrastructure or should be funded/handled by another organisation or in a different way.

3 - B: The described need could not be fulfilled by an infrastructure of national interest. (Less relevant grade for existing infrastructures.)

4 - A3: The described need could be fulfilled by an infrastructure of national interest, but the thematic area is not considered ready for call. (Less relevant grade for existing infrastructures.)

5 - A2: The described need could be fulfilled by an infrastructure of national interest within VR's remit, and if the available funding and strategic considerations so allow, the infrastructure could be considered eligible for call.

6 - A1: The described need is of highest priority and is considered ready for call (new needs) / the infrastructure is eligible to seek renewed funding (existing infrastructures). Only used by RFI.

Swedigarch provides an important resource for connecting environmental and cultural historical data. The transition from an emerging to an operational phase is credible, and the development plan is realistic, where the absence of major structural changes suggests organisational stability. The proposed increase in staffing and budget is substantial, but is, in general, justified if it encompasses expansions into more datasets, as much archaeological data remains inaccessible, despite its quantitative nature suitable for large-scale open access.
In summary, Swedigarch has clear national relevance, solid scientific foundations, and broad community engagement.

Medskick från RFI:
Inför beslut om resultat från behovsinventeringen 2025-2026 har RFI utgått från RÅG:s bedömning av förslagen med betyg A2 och valt att ge de högst prioriterade infrastrukturerna betyget A1, som är en förutsättning men inte en garanti för att vara behörig att söka i utlysningen forskningsinfrastruktur av nationellt intresse 2027. Övriga högt prioriterade förslag har kvarstått på betyget A2. RFI:s beslut grundar sig på en samlad bedömning av förslagen med högst prioritet i behovsinventeringen och rådets strategiska diskussioner.
RFI:s betyg: A1